

Exquisite Corpse Activity

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Objective

Students will collaboratively create unique and imaginative stories or drawings using the Exquisite Corpse technique, enhancing their creativity, teamwork, and understanding of collaborative art and writing.

Materials

- Paper (for drawing and/or writing)
- Pencils, pens, or markers
- Optional: Folded or sectioned paper for art activities

Lesson Plan

Introduction to Exquisite Corpse

What is Exquisite Corpse?

- **Exquisite Corpse** is a collaborative game where multiple people contribute to a single work of art or writing, without knowing what the others have added. The result is a surreal and often surprising piece, showcasing the creativity of the group as a whole.

How it Began:

- The game was invented by Surrealist artists in the early 20th century as a way to explore the power of the unconscious mind and the unexpected results of collaboration. The name "Exquisite Corpse" comes from a sentence that was formed during one of the first games: "The exquisite corpse shall drink the new wine."

How to Play:

- **In Writing:** Each participant writes a part of a sentence or story on a piece of paper, then folds the paper to hide their contribution and passes it to the next person. The next participant continues the story without knowing what was previously written. This continues until the story is complete, and then it's read aloud to reveal the unexpected narrative.
- **In Drawing:** A piece of paper is divided into sections. The first participant draws the head of a creature or character in the top section, folds the paper to hide their drawing, and passes it on. The next person draws the torso without seeing the head, and so on, until the entire figure is complete. The final result is a bizarre and imaginative creature that combines everyone's contributions.

Activity Instructions

1. Choose Your Version:

- Decide whether the class will be doing a writing or drawing version of Exquisite Corpse. You can also split the class into two groups, with one group doing the writing version and the other doing the drawing version.

2. Divide into Groups:

- Break the class into small groups of 4-5 students. Each group will need a set of papers and writing/drawing materials.

3. Set Up the Paper:

- **For Writing:** Hand out a piece of paper to each group. Students should write the first part of a sentence (for example, "Once upon a time...") or a prompt at the top of the paper.
- **For Drawing:** Distribute a piece of paper folded into thirds or quarters. The first student draws the head of a creature in the top section, then folds the paper to hide their drawing before passing it on.

4. Begin the Activity:

- Students should take turns writing or drawing their part, folding the paper to hide their contribution before passing it on to the next person.
- Encourage them to be imaginative and not worry about making sense—this is part of the fun!

Debrief and Discussion

1. Reveal the Results:

- Once each group has finished, have them unfold their papers and reveal their collaborative work. Each group can take turns sharing their story or creature with the class.

2. Discuss:

- Ask the students what surprised them about the final results. Did they expect the story or drawing to turn out the way it did? What was the most surprising part?
- Discuss how the activity highlights the importance of collaboration and how working together can lead to unexpected and creative outcomes.

Wrap-Up

1. Reflection:

- Have students reflect on what they learned from the activity. They can write a short paragraph or share their thoughts verbally. Questions could include:
 - What did you enjoy most about the Exquisite Corpse activity?
 - How did it feel to contribute to something without knowing what others were doing?
 - What did you learn about creativity and collaboration?

2. Optional Extension:

- If time permits, encourage students to take the results of their Exquisite Corpse and create a more polished story to serve as a basis for a video game.

Possible Prompts for the Game

Writing Prompts:

1. "In a hidden corner of the universe, a strange creature was discovered..."
2. "The old book was filled with secrets, but no one expected to find..."
3. "As the clock struck midnight, something unusual happened in the small town..."
4. "The mysterious map led them to a place where..."
5. "On the first day of summer, the sky turned a color no one had ever seen before..."

Drawing Prompts:

1. A creature that has never been seen before.
2. A character from a dream or a nightmare.
3. An alien from another planet.
4. A hybrid animal combining two or more different species.
5. A magical being with unusual powers.